

What the Government's UFO Files Actually Say

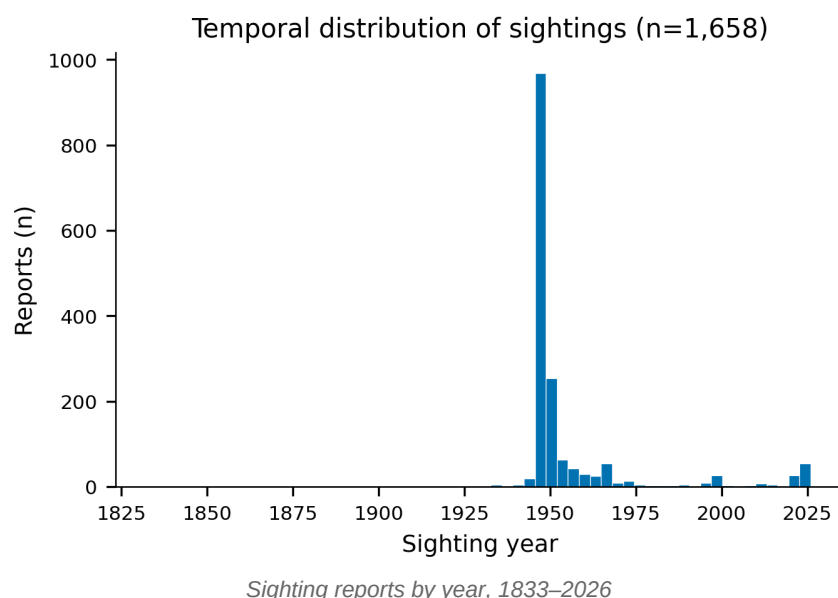
A data-driven look at 1,873 declassified UAP sighting reports

PURSUE Data Project · July 2026

Nearly two thousand declassified sighting reports, pulled straight from the Department of War's own UAP release archive. No speculation, no theories — just what's actually in the paperwork the government chose to make public. Here's what the numbers show.

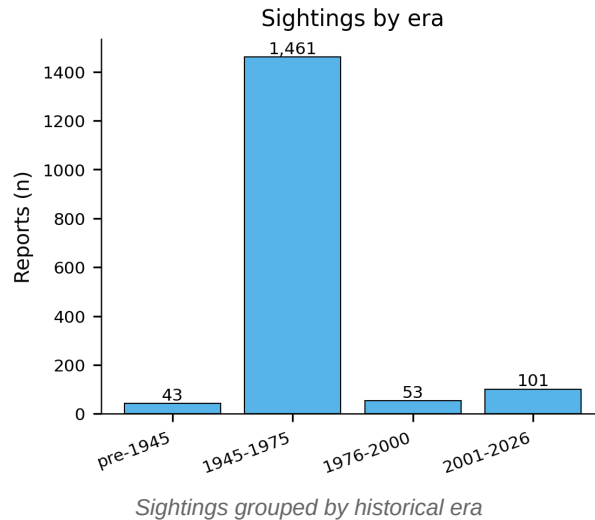
A Wave of Sightings That Still Defines the Story

If you plot every sighting in this archive by year, one thing jumps out immediately: a single, enormous spike.



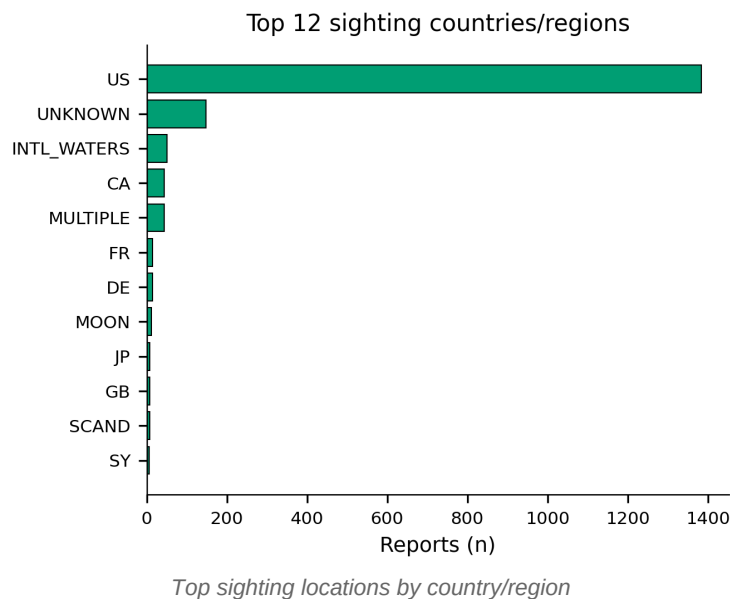
1947. Almost a thousand individual reports cluster around that one year — dwarfing everything before or after it. This is the “flying disc” summer, the moment the phrase “flying saucer” entered the American vocabulary after pilot Kenneth Arnold's sighting near Mount Rainier in June 1947. What this chart shows is just how seriously the reporting apparatus took it at the time: whatever people were seeing that summer, the government was writing it down by the hundreds.

Zoom out to the broader eras and the pattern holds:



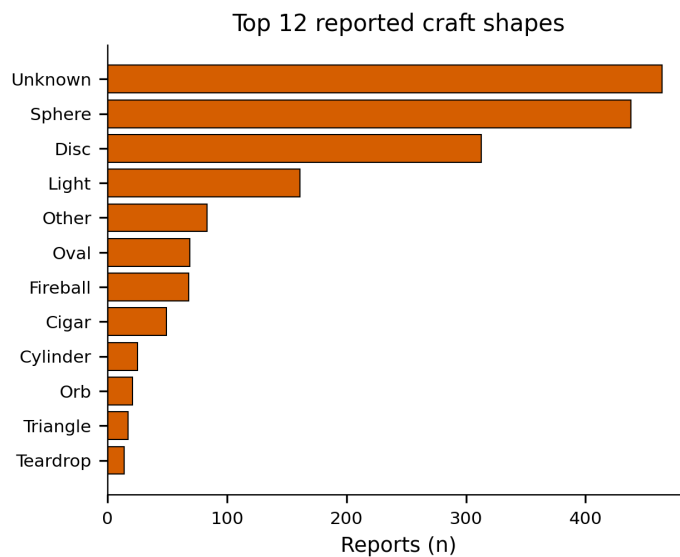
Three out of every four reports in this archive fall in the 1945–1975 window — the early Cold War decades when radar, jet aircraft, and nuclear anxiety were all colliding for the first time. The modern era (2001–2026) is a much smaller slice, not because sightings stopped, but because this particular archive is weighted toward the older, newly-declassified material.

Where in the World



Unsurprisingly, the overwhelming majority of reports — 1,383 of them — are tied to the United States. But look past the top bar: “INTERNATIONAL WATERS” shows up as its own distinct category with 51 reports. These are sightings logged by ships and aircraft crews out at sea, far from any coastline — exactly the kind of witness (trained military observers, standardized instrumentation, no light pollution) that skeptics usually wish they had more of.

What Are People Actually Seeing?

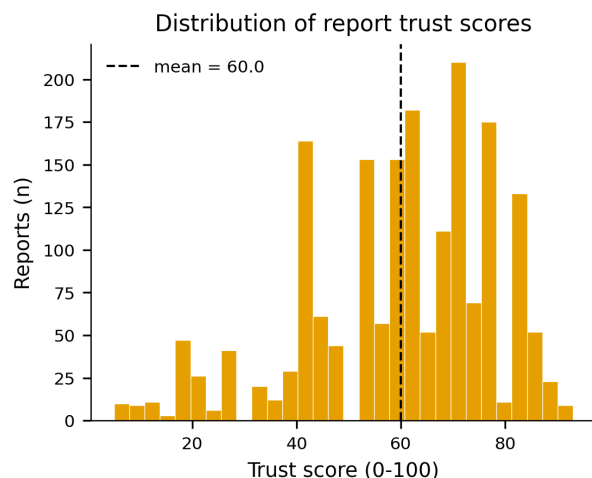


Top reported craft shapes

Strip away the “Unknown” category (464 reports — the honest majority, since most witnesses genuinely can't pin down a precise shape in the moment) and two shapes dominate everything else: **Sphere** (438) and **Disc** (313). Between them, spheres and discs account for more reports than every other named shape combined — triangles, cylinders, and the rest trail well behind. If you've ever wondered whether “flying saucer” was just a 1947 media invention or an actual recurring pattern in what people report, this chart is the closest thing to an answer: the disc shape shows up again and again, decades apart, across completely unrelated witnesses.

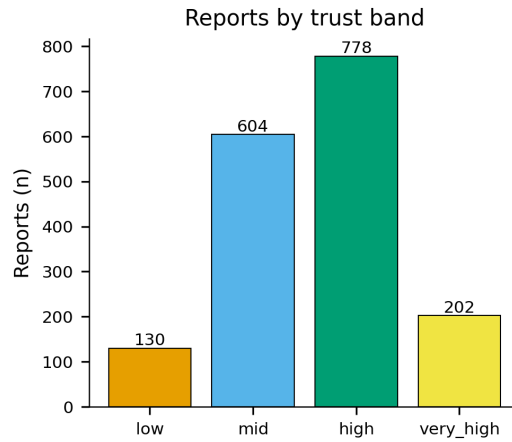
How Much Do We Trust These Reports?

Every report in this archive carries a trust score — a 0–100 rating based on witness credibility, corroboration, and internal consistency.



Distribution of report trust scores

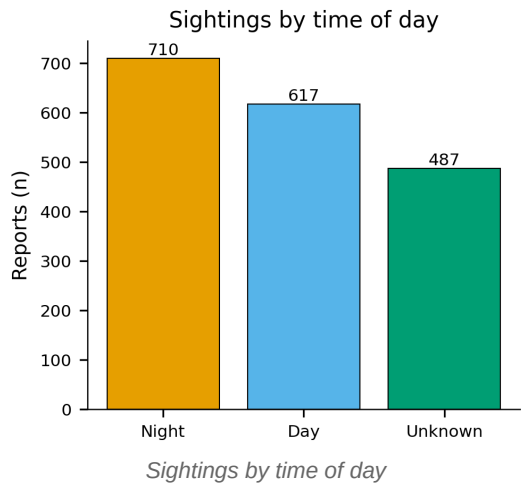
The average sits at 60 out of 100, and the distribution is broad rather than clustered at the bottom — this isn't a pile of obviously dismissible reports. Break it into bands and the picture gets sharper:



Reports grouped by trust band

Nearly a thousand reports — high plus very-high combined — sit in the upper trust tiers. That's not a fringe minority; that's close to half the entire archive rated as credible-to-highly-credible by whatever standard produced this score.

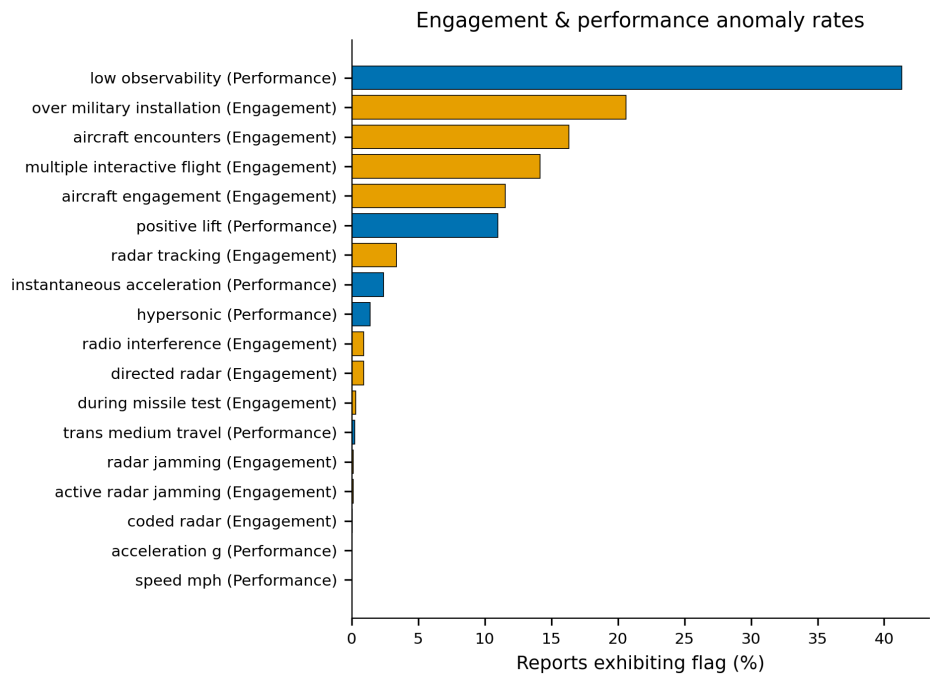
Night Sky, Day Sky



Slightly more sightings happen at night (710) than during the day (617), which tracks with intuition — unusual lights are easier to notice against a dark sky. But the daytime number is far from negligible, and it argues against the easy dismissal that this is all just misidentified stars, planets, or aircraft lights. A disc-shaped object reported at 617 daylight sightings isn't explained by “it was probably Venus.”

Encounters With the Military

This is where the archive gets genuinely striking. A cluster of fields track whether a sighting involved some form of direct interaction with military assets or defied conventional physics:

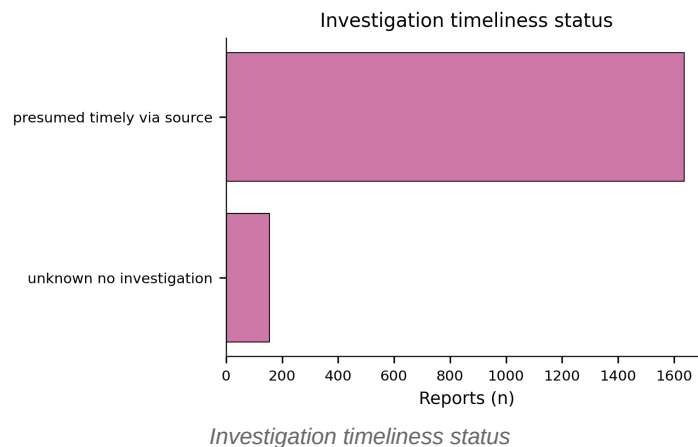


Engagement and performance anomaly rates across the corpus

- **41.3%** of reports flag “low observability” — the object was hard to track on radar or visually, despite being seen.
- **20.6%** occurred directly over a **military installation**.
- **16.3%** involved a direct **aircraft encounter**.
- **14.2%** described **multiple interactive flight** maneuvers — the object appeared to respond to the observer.
- **11.5%** logged an **aircraft engagement** specifically.
- **11%** exhibited **positive lift** with no visible means of propulsion.

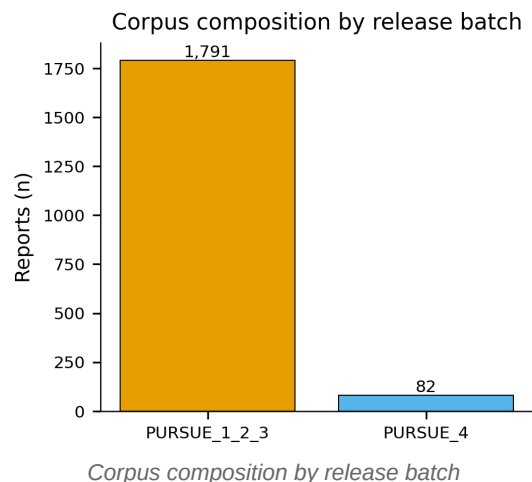
Read that first line again: two out of every five reports in this archive involve something that shouldn't have been hard to track, but was. And a full fifth of all reports happened directly over sensitive military ground. This isn't background noise — it's a recurring signature across a dataset spanning eighty years.

Where the Investigations Stand Today



Most of the archive — 1,637 reports — is marked “presumed timely via source,” meaning the original documentation was processed close to when the sighting occurred. A smaller set, 154 reports, are flagged as having had no formal investigation at the time. Put together, this is a body of evidence that was, for the most part, actually looked at when it came in — not simply filed away and forgotten.

Who Released This



This report draws on 1,873 sighting records spanning four separate document releases from the Department of War, published between May and July 2026 — the most substantial voluntary release of UAP-related material in the program's history. The bulk of the archive (1,791 reports) comes from the first three releases; the newest batch adds another 82 documents, several of which — after cross-checking — turned out to describe events already on record in the earlier releases, corroborating each other independently.

Source: PURSUE government-release corpus, compiled from official Department of War UAP document releases 1–4 (war.gov/UFO). Figures generated from the merged sighting-report dataset; full technical documentation available in the project repository.